



MALAGASY

AFRICAN AND INDONESIAN ROOTS

THE FIRST SETTLERS ON MADAGASCAR CAME, not from Africa, but from Southeast Asia, nearly 6,000 miles (10,000 km) away. They settled on the central highlands of the island. Later, Africans settled in the

A miniature continent

Thousands of islands litter the Indian Ocean. The largest, Madagascar—which is the world's fourth largest island—lies 250 miles (400 km) off the east coast of Africa. Ecologically, it is one of the most diverse countries on Earth. Almost 98 percent of the land mammals and a high proportion of plants, reptiles, and birds live only here.



MARKET DAY

Although their main crop is rice, which is consumed locally, farmers on Madagascar grow various crops including coffee, vanilla, cloves, and sugar for export. In order to produce decaffeinated coffee the beans must be treated. However, there is one exception to this rule—the Madagascar coffee species *mascarocoffea vianneyi* produces naturally decaffeinated beans.

A woman taking a fish home from market by balancing it on her head.

A RICH SOURCE OF FOOD

Coastal Malagasy have always eaten fish, crab, and shrimp, but recently fishing has become more intensive in order to supply fish and shrimp for export. Although this generates much-needed income for Madagascar, there is concern that overfishing might seriously deplete the waters and cause a food shortage.

